

time to assemble his troops. When all the bridging equipment had arrived at the end of the month, the two halves of Lee's army—General James Longstreet's and General Stonewall Jackson's corps—were facing Burnside's soldiers across the river. Because of the long delay, both sides had plenty of time to prepare their positions. Burnside placed his artillery above Fredericksburg on Stafford Heights to the east—such a weight of firepower that not even Lee could contemplate taking the offensive.

On the other side of the river, Longstreet took up position on Marye's Heights behind the town, amassing a formidable concentration of artillery and infantry along the base of the ridge, while Jackson spread out his forces downstream to his right. Lee had a panoramic view of the battlefield from a nearby hilltop. In all, the Confederate troops ranged across 8 miles (13km) of ridges along the western side of the valley. A frontal assault on such prepared defenses, held by more than 70,000 men, many of whom had a clear view of the plain beneath them, was unlikely to succeed. But Burnside felt committed to the operation and would not call it off. On the morning of December 11, the bridging of the river began. Although the fire from the Union guns on Stafford Heights made it impossible for Confederate troops to advance in the open to the riverbank and contest the crossing, the buildings of Fredericksburg, now deserted by the civilians, made excellent cover for sharpshooters of the Mississippi brigade. Northern engineers struggled to complete the pontoons under their harassing fire. Union artillery reduced much of the town to rubble, but the sharpshooters were not driven out until a Union advance guard crossed by boat and flushed them out.

**900** The number of enemy that General Robert E. Lee reported he had taken prisoner following the Battle of Fredericksburg.